

quality of life in Africa by establishing schools and hospitals; however, missionary workers also inflicted their white imperialist values on the indigenous population, so destroying local traditions. Education is probably the area where female missionaries had the most positive impact. Ironically, most of the people who later fought for African independence were educated by missionaries.

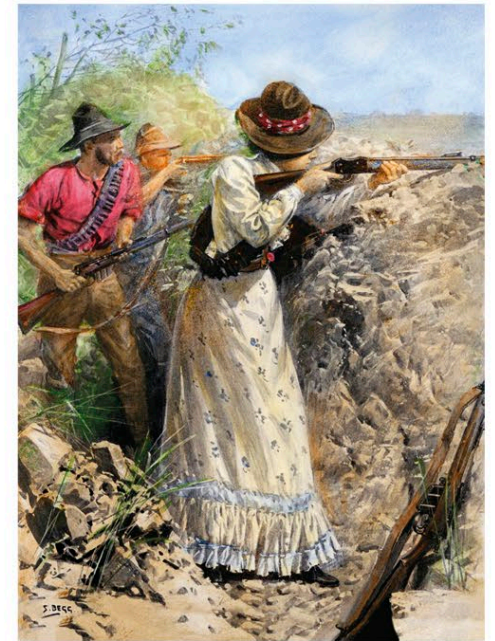
The colonization of Africa came at huge human cost. Those Africans who were unwilling to labor for colonizers were sometimes violently coerced. In the Belgian Congo, methods were especially brutal: for example, the hands of women, men, and children who failed to meet rubber-harvesting quotas were routinely chopped off, and women

were sometimes held hostage to force the men to work. In addition, imperial appropriation of communally held land, in the Belgian Congo and elsewhere on the continent, impacted women's traditional role in agriculture. As communal land was reduced and the different types of crops were restricted in order to maximize cash crops for export, women's traditional status as the cultivators of land was undermined. At the same time, as men began to travel to work in mines and factories, women had less help at home, so increasing their labor but not their status.

Casualties and combatants

The jockeying for control and resources on the continent also led to colonial clashes, such as the Boer Wars, between the British, who were expanding into southern Africa, and the Transvaal Republic, an independent country founded in 1852 by Dutch-speaking farmers of the eastern Cape (the Boers). During the Second Boer War (1900–1902), the British, unable to counter the guerrilla-style tactics of the Boers, removed the Boers' support base by rounding up all non-combatants, including women and children, and placing them in concentration camps. These camps were poorly administered and overcrowded and many of the incarcerated died from hunger and disease.

Yet women were not simply passive victims of the conflict in South Africa—some determined individuals fought alongside male fighters. Patriotic Boer Sarah Raal, for example, escaped from a camp and joined her brothers in a commando unit. On the British side, Lady Sarah Wilson, an aunt of Winston Churchill, became the first female war correspondent after writing about the Siege of Mafeking, and Emily Hobhouse, an English philanthropist and social worker, reported on abhorrent conditions in the British camps. After reading Hobhouse's report, suffragette Millicent Fawcett (see pp. 206–209) spent five months visiting the camps as part of an official enquiry that led to substantial improvements, although thousands still perished.



▲ Lady Sharpshooter

British settler Mrs. Davies fires on Boer positions during the 217-day siege of Mafeking in 1900. Tales of the plucky woman were widely published in British newspapers.



4,000
of the **28,000**
who died in Boer
concentration
camps were
women